

Understanding Social Anxiety Disorder Through Attachment Theory

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Social anxiety disorder is commonly defined through its symptoms, such as fear, avoidance, and distress in social situations. However, attachment theory gives insight into examining how symptoms of social anxiety disorder may have emerged developmentally. This paper discusses the associations between attachment theory and social anxiety disorder by examining interpersonal expectations, maladaptive emotion regulation, and behavioral inhibition in the context of attachment insecurity. In a survey of college freshmen transitioning to college, research shows that individuals with secure attachment had fewer social anxiety symptoms. Research further shows that, in an online survey, anxious attachment and avoidant attachment were associated with social anxiety symptoms and were partially mediated by maladaptive emotion regulation strategies. Lastly, longitudinal research shows an association with insecure attachment, behavioral inhibition, and social anxiety symptoms. This research, taken together, does not suggest causation between attachment theory and SAD, but instead highlights an association through interpersonal expectations of rejection, maladaptive emotion regulation, and vulnerability among behaviorally inhibited individuals. Attachment theory, therefore, offers a useful developmental and relational approach for understanding social anxiety disorder and informing treatment.

Keywords: attachment theory, social anxiety disorder, emotion regulation, behavioral inhibition, internal working models

"Only when a sense of security is restored can a potential caregiver perceive others as not only potential sources of security and support but also as worthy human beings who themselves need and deserve sympathy and support" (Mikulincer & Shaver, 2016). This quote proposes a fundamental concept of attachment theory: security is learned. It propagates from person to person, from friend to friend, and from caregiver to child, shaping the expectations for interpersonal relations that persist into adulthood. The theory states that individuals raised in sensitive and reliable environments may become comfortable with closeness and with expressing distress to others, through the relationships between the child and the caregiver, and that these expectations may carry over into future relationships. Inversely, the theory adds that unreliable and insensitive care may lead to expectations of relationships as unreliable, unsafe, or rejecting. This is especially important when understanding social anxiety disorder (SAD) – a debilitating condition where social interaction can feel threatening and overwhelming. Driven by a fear of social judgment, rejection, or embarrassment, people with SAD tend to withdraw from social environments and interactions. Rather than viewing SAD as a set of symptoms, attachment theory looks deeper to explore how expectations for rejection, support, and emotional safety can contribute to the development of this disorder. Through the lens of attachment theory, the development of social anxiety disorder can be understood by exploring interpersonal expectations from insecure working models, maladaptive emotion regulation, and the interaction between attachment insecurity and behavioral inhibition.

Attachment Theory and Internal Working Models

Attachment theory states that the relationship between a child and caregiver shapes the child's expectations of themselves and others. When a child cries and receives consistent, sensitive care, the child may view the caregiver as a secure base they can trust in unfamiliar or distressing situations. From this security, the child may learn two things: (1) in a time of distress, they can receive

external support that is helpful and comforting; (2) they themselves are worthy of this support. These two expectations reflect how the child views themselves (whether they are worthy of support) and how they view others (whether others may provide support), and the theory states that these views carry over into their interpersonal relationships in the future.

These expectations are described as internal working models. The theory began with John Bowlby's initial proposition that child-caregiver interactions shape children's expectations (Bowlby, 1969), was later refined into three styles of infant attachment by Ainsworth et al. (1978), and then later into four by Main and Solomon (1986). Afterward, Bartholomew and Horowitz (1991) adapted this model into four types of adult attachment. Infant and adult attachment models use different terms, but both rely on the principal idea that earlier relational experiences shape expectations about the self and others. For clarity, this paper has simply labeled the internal working models as secure, anxious, avoidant, and fearful.

Attachment theory proposes that the caregiver's sensitivity and consistency contribute to one of the four attachment styles. A positive self-view and a positive view of others are associated with secure attachment; a positive self-view and a negative view of others are associated with avoidant attachment; a negative self-view and a positive view of others are associated with anxious attachment; and a negative self-view and a negative view of others are associated with fearful attachment. Children with an inconsistent but partially sensitive upbringing may see that they can receive support from others (a positive view of others), but may believe that the support they receive is inconsistent because they are not deserving of it (a negative self-view). As the child grows older, they may maintain the belief that external support is available but that they are not worthy of it, leading them to be anxious about closeness, rejection, and relationship security. These internal working models are especially relevant in the context of social anxiety disorder because they may help illustrate how individuals with SAD might interpret social interactions and

interpersonal relationships with expectations of rejection, judgment, or emotional insecurity.

Social Anxiety Disorder

Social anxiety disorder (SAD) is a persistent fear and anxiety toward social situations. SAD can be severe and debilitating: individuals with SAD may exclude themselves from social interaction and withdraw from relationships, even when this avoidance impairs daily functions (American Psychiatric Association, 2022). People with SAD may be intensely opposed to common social activities such as public speaking, meeting new people, dating, or other social circumstances, causing severe anxiety (National Institute of Mental Health, 2025). Because of this, people with SAD often use avoidance or safety behaviors that reduce immediate anxiety (Evans et al., 2021; Kim, 2005) but prevent opportunities for close relationships and corrective experiences that could challenge their fear of rejection. Since SAD centers on fearful expectations in social interactions, analyzing it with an understanding of attachment theory can be especially useful for exploring the disorder's development.

Interpersonal Expectations and Social Anxiety

The expectations of fear and rejection from others seen in social anxiety disorder can be explained through attachment theory because of how insecure internal working models set up expectations for interpersonal relations. Attachment theory states that children with available, accepting, and supportive relationships are more likely to develop secure attachment; in turn, they have the capacity to expect availability and support from others. Likewise, children who experience inconsistent, rejecting, or emotionally unavailable caregiving may be more likely to develop insecure attachment and may fear the same response patterns in other relationships. Carcedo et al. (2023) explored this by following 210 college freshmen as they transitioned to college. They measured parental attachment before the transition and then followed up six months later to assess satisfaction with interpersonal relationships, social anxiety, and loneliness in college. They found that insecure parental attachment predicted social anxiety symptoms, and subjects with higher symptoms of social anxiety had less ease in forming friendships and less satisfaction in the quality of their friendships. Although these results do not establish causation, they support the idea that early relationship security is meaningfully associated with later interpersonal functioning. Attachment theory would suggest that prior attachment insecurity may have shaped an insecure internal working model. This model may have contributed to unsupportive expectations for themselves, others, and shared relationships. When students transition to college, these negative expectations may make new relationships and maintaining them through social interaction feel more threatening, contributing to symptoms of social anxiety.

Emotion Regulation and Social Anxiety

Emotion regulation is the process of monitoring and modifying emotional reactions to achieve goals. Stress management is a common example of emotion regulation, in which a person might go for a walk, console a friend, or take a break with the goal of alleviating stress. Alternatively, they might choose an unhealthy or maladaptive strategy to regulate their emotions, such

as dwelling on their stress, becoming depressed, anxious, or having impulsive outbursts. These are examples of emotion regulation strategies and can be either healthy or maladaptive depending on the context. Cognitive reappraisal is an emotion regulation strategy that involves reinterpreting a situation to a more positive perspective. For example, being angry after being cut off on the freeway, then reassessing the situation and wondering if it was an emergency, such as giving birth. Another example of an emotion regulation strategy is suppression, in which the emotion is still felt internally but masked externally. An example would be hearing an upsetting joke and forcing a laugh or smile to avoid making a scene. While cognitive reappraisal is generally considered healthy and effective at regulating emotions, and suppression is considered maladaptive and ineffective, the situation context matters: some situations are inappropriate for reappraisal and appropriate for suppression.

Attachment theory gives context to the formation of social anxiety disorder by showing how both attachment and SAD are connected to emotion regulation strategies. People with secure attachment tend to use more effective and healthier coping strategies than those with insecure attachment. This is especially prevalent when investigating attachment anxiety, where people may become hyperaware of signs of rejection, reassurance, or abandonment. Read et al. (2018) conducted an online survey measuring attachment, emotion regulation strategies, and social anxiety. They found that attachment anxiety and attachment avoidance were positively associated with social anxiety symptoms. They also found that attachment anxiety was associated with lower cognitive reappraisal and higher suppression, and that these emotion regulation strategies partially mediated the relationship between attachment anxiety and social anxiety. From the data, it is evident that the relationships between attachment insecurity and social anxiety can be partially explained by emotion regulation strategies. Attachment theory would suggest that because people with insecure attachment may have difficulty trusting themselves and others during distress, they are less likely to seek support. Instead of seeking external support, they may find alternative coping mechanisms such as avoidance. In turn, if individuals with insecure attachment are less likely to use cognitive reappraisal, they may have more difficulty interpreting neutral cues, such as silence or awkwardness, in less threatening ways. Instead, they may interpret these cues as signs of rejection or judgment. Attachment theory would suggest that these avoidance tendencies and hyperawareness of signs of rejection may contribute to the development of SAD symptoms.

Behavioral Inhibition and Social Anxiety

Attachment may also influence risks for social anxiety disorder when understood with behavioral inhibition. Behavioral inhibition is a temperamental tendency for shyness, reserve, or sensitivity to unfamiliarity. Lewis-Morrarty et al. (2015) studied 165 subjects, measuring their attachment security at infancy and behavioral inhibition during childhood. Afterward, the researchers examined whether those earlier developmental factors predicted social anxiety symptoms during adolescence. They found that both infant attachment security and behavioral inhibition were significant predictors of social anxiety symptoms. While attachment security does not necessarily cause behavioral inhibition, attachment theory would suggest that it may shape whether responses to unfamiliar situations are seen as either manageable or threatening. Attachment theory would suggest that a natural tendency toward withdrawal,

when combined with insecure attachment, may make avoidance more likely. Over time, this avoidance may prevent corrective social experiences and contribute to the development or maintenance of SAD symptoms.

Conclusion

Applying concepts of attachment theory to social anxiety disorder, the disorder can be analyzed by connecting symptoms of SAD to expectations in interpersonal relationships, emotion regulation, and behavioral inhibition. Negative interpersonal expectations from attachment insecurity mirror symptoms of SAD, such as fear of rejection, humiliation, or social interaction. In addition, attachment insecurity may influence emotion regulation by making individuals more likely to adopt maladaptive strategies, such as avoidance and suppression, rather than cognitive reappraisal. Finally, the intersection between attachment and behavioral inhibition may make some individuals especially vulnerable to developing social anxiety symptoms. Together, these findings suggest that applying attachment theory to SAD can help provide a more comprehensive understanding of its underlying mechanisms.

By applying the principles of attachment theory to SAD, strategies for secure attachment can be used more proactively to address SAD symptoms. Zhang et al. (2023) conducted an experiment, priming one group with attachment security priming over two weeks and comparing it to a control group. After the two weeks, researchers found a decrease in social anxiety symptoms in the priming group with no significant change for the control group. Although this source does not prove long-term effects of attachment security on SAD, it suggests that attachment-based approaches may help reduce symptoms of social anxiety disorder. Therefore, attachment theory does not replace existing explanations of SAD, but it provides a useful developmental framework for understanding and treating the disorder.

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